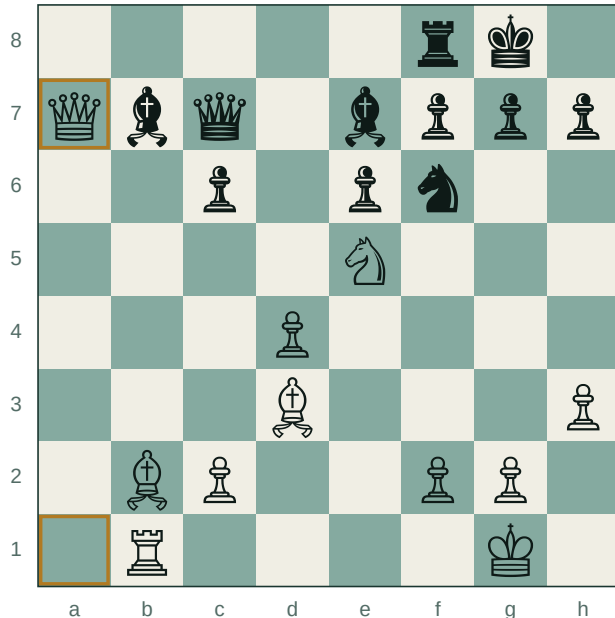


Trapping a piece: Black, move 21

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Qa7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Ra8 22. Qxa8+ Bxa8

21...Ra8 The rook moves from f8 to a8. Recorded reply: **22.Qxa8+**.

22...Bxa8 The bishop captures the queen on a8.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 23 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4:** the balance goes from +0 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on a7 and rook on b1. Check for tactical protection.